

ONE SMALL CENTIMETRE FOR MAN, A GIANT LEAP FOR DUPLANTIS

POLE-VAULTER ARMAND DUPLANTIS IS SO FAR AHEAD OF THE REST OF THE FIELD, HE CAN **CONTINUE TO BREAK THE WORLD RECORD ONE CENTIMETRE AT A TIME. BUT JUST HOW FAR CAN HE GO?**

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No medals are awarded at the Diamond League competition in track-and-field, but a day before the Silesia Diamond League competition in August, organisers announced an award for the most valuable athlete of the meet, as judged by the World Athletics points system. At the customary pre-competition press conference, they displayed a sparkling 14-carat gold diamond-encrusted 'Champion Ring' worth \$10,000, along with a cheque for the same amount.

On a sweltering August afternoon at the Silesian stadium the next day, it had seemed that that ring was going to be firmly on the finger of Jakob Ingebrigtsen. The Norwegian shattered one of the longest-standing track world records, clocking a staggering 7:17.55 for the 3000m, taking more than three seconds off the mark of

7:20.67 set by Kenya's Daniel Komen in 1996. It was one of the most remarkable moments in track and field history.

But it wasn't the most remarkable event of that day. Because Armand Duplantis was also competing.

He had already started the men's pole vault competition while Ingebrigtsen was running. Ten other athletes were competing. By the time he had casually attempted his second jump — to seal his place in the top three, his competitors had gone through 64 of their own. The next three made another 13 jumps, while Duplantis went on top with a single clearance at six metres. Two jumpers cleared six metres — the first time in history that three pole vaulters have